

Chapter 4 — What Books and Burials Tell Us

The Vedic Age + The Megalith Builders

The one-line point: After the cities fell, India goes almost silent archaeologically — but starts *speaking* through the **Rigveda**. Meanwhile, in the south and the Deccan, people were building **giant stone burials**. Two utterly different windows into the same thousand years.

← Ch.3 | Index | Next: Ch.5 →

Syllabus Classification

Field	Value
Subject	History → Ancient India
Sub-discipline	Vedic Period (Proto-history → Early Historic) + Megalithic / Iron Age cultures
Period	~1500 BCE – 600 BCE (Rigveda ~1500–1000 BCE; Later Vedic ~1000–600 BCE); Megaliths ~1000 BCE – 100 CE
Prelims (GS Paper I)	<i>History of India</i> → Vedic literature, society, Harappan vs Vedic comparison ★
Mains (GS Paper I)	<i>Indian culture</i> : Vedic literature as heritage; also Indian Society — origins of varna/caste
Also feeds	Art & Culture (Vedic literature, Sanskrit), Indian Society (caste origins, gender), Polity (roots of <i>sabha/samiti</i> → assemblies), Ethics/Essay (social stratification)
Weightage	★★★★★ — very high. The Harappan-vs-Vedic contrast is a repeat performer
Overlaps with	The Aryan migration debate (current affairs + genetics); Saraswati river debate

 **Ancient India, still.** But note the split personality of this chapter: the **Vedic half** is pure literary history and feeds Art & Culture + Indian Society; the **Megalith half** is pure archaeology and feeds nothing but Prelims. Study them as two separate topics that happen to share a chapter.

Learning Outcomes

By the end of this chapter you should be able to:

- ☐ **Name and describe** the four Vedas, and rank them by antiquity.
- ☐ **State** the key numbers of the Rigveda — 1028 hymns, 10 mandalas, which mandalas are oldest/latest.
- ☐ **Describe** Rigvedic society: the *raja*, *sabha*, *samiti*, *vidatha*, *gana*, *jana*, and why there were **no taxes, no capital and no standing army**.
- ☐ **Explain** the terms *dasa/dasyu*, *arya/anarya*, *gavishti*, *purohita*, and what they reveal about social division.
- ☐ **Narrate** the **Battle of Ten Kings** (*Dasarajna*) — participants, river, outcome.
- ☐ **List** the Rigvedic rivers and locate the *Sapta Sindhava*.
- ☐ **Compare** Early Vedic vs Later Vedic society across at least six dimensions.
- ☐ **Trace** the origin of the **varna** system to the *Purusha Sukta*, and explain how it hardened over time.

- ☐ **Define** a megalith and distinguish its types (cist, dolmen, menhir, urn burial, port-hole).
- ☐ **Explain** how archaeologists infer **social inequality from burials** — and the limits of that inference.
- ☐ **Describe** the Inamgaon evidence and what it tells us about a Chalcolithic village.
- ☐ **Compare Harappan vs Vedic culture** point-by-point (a guaranteed Prelims format).
- ☐ **State neutrally** the terms of the Aryan migration debate.

Start Here: The Strangest Reversal in Indian History

Look at what just happened between Chapter 3 and Chapter 4:

HARAPPANS (Ch.3)	VEDIC PEOPLE (Ch.4)
MOUNTAINS of physical evidence Cities! Drains! Seals! Weights! Statues! ZERO readable text We know their PLUMBING but not their GODS.	MOUNTAINS of TEXT 1,028 hymns we can read word for word ALMOST NO archaeology No cities. No monuments Barely any settlements We know their GODS but not their PLUMBING.
PERFECT MIRROR IMAGES OF EACH OTHER	

This inversion is the whole point of the chapter title: "What *Books* and *Burials* Tell Us." Books = the Vedic texts. Burials = the megaliths. **Two completely different kinds of evidence, each answering what the other cannot.**

 **You've seen this exact problem.** One service has rich structured logs but you can't see its state. Another has full state dumps but zero logging. Neither alone gives you the picture — **you have to correlate across sources.** That's the historian's job here.

The Software Engineer's Analogy

The **Rigveda** is the most extraordinary piece of data replication in human history.

THE RIGVEDA AS A REPLICATION SYSTEM

Composed ~1500 BCE (orally)
First written ~1400 CE (roughly)
Gap ~3,000 YEARS of PURE ORAL TRANSMISSION

Storage medium: HUMAN MEMORY
Replication: father → son, guru → shishya
Integrity checks: MULTIPLE redundant recitation patterns –
jata-patha, ghana-patha: the same verse recited
in permuted word-orders, so that ANY dropped or
swapped word breaks the pattern audibly
→ a CHECKSUM, implemented in prosody
Result: Different lineages, thousands of km apart,
preserve near-identical text.
UNESCO lists Vedic chanting as Intangible
Cultural Heritage (2008).

🧠 **Sit with that for a second.** A society with no writing built an error-detecting code out of *recitation patterns* and used it to replicate a large text across 3,000 years with astonishingly low drift. It's a hand-rolled, human-executed integrity protocol. Chapter 1 warned you that manuscripts drift — **the Vedic tradition engineered around exactly that problem.**

PART A — 📖 THE BOOKS: The Vedic Age

1 The Four Vedas

"Veda" means "knowledge." These are the oldest surviving texts in any Indo-European language.

Veda	Content	Note
1. RIGVEDA ★ ★ ★	1,028 hymns (suktas) in praise of gods, in 10 books (mandalas)	The OLDEST (~3,500 years ago / ~1500 BCE). The only one Class 6 covers in detail
2. SAMAVEDA	The Rigvedic hymns set to melody for chanting	The root of Indian classical music ★
3. YAJURVEDA	Ritual formulae — the procedures for performing sacrifices	The "how-to manual"
4. ATHARVAVEDA	Charms, spells, magic, folk medicine, everyday concerns	The most "popular"/non-priestly; a window into ordinary life

🎯 **Prelims essentials:** Rigveda = oldest, **1,028 hymns, 10 mandalas**. Samaveda = **music**. Atharvaveda = **magic/medicine**. These four one-liners are asked directly.

Structure of the Rigveda

- **10 mandalas** (books)
- **Mandalas 2–7** are the **oldest core** — the "family books," each attributed to a priestly family
- **Mandalas 1, 8, 9, 10** are **later additions**
- **Mandala 9** is devoted entirely to **Soma**
- **Mandala 10** contains the famous **Purusha Sukta** ★ (the varna origin hymn) and the **Nasadiya Sukta** (the "creation hymn" — a remarkably sceptical text that asks whether even the gods know how the universe began)

The gods

Deity	Domain	Frequency
Indra ★	War, thunder, rain; the warrior-king god	Most hymns (~250)
Agni ★	Fire; the messenger who carries offerings to the gods	Second (~200)
Soma ★	A plant and the intoxicating ritual drink made from it	Whole of Mandala 9
Varuna	Cosmic and moral order (<i>rita</i>)	Important, fewer hymns
Ushas	Dawn (female deity)	Beautiful hymns
Rudra, Vayu, Surya, Mitra, Yama, Prithvi, Aditi	Storm, wind, sun, contracts, death, earth, mother of gods	Various

🗨️ **The pattern to notice:** Rigvedic gods are **forces of nature**, and the most-praised is a **war god**. That tells you the society's priorities: rain, fire, cattle, and victory in battle. Contrast this with Harappan religion — where the visible motifs are the mother goddess, the pipal tree, and a seated yogic figure. **Very different religious worlds.**

Language

- The Rigveda is in **Vedic Sanskrit** — an early, archaic form of Sanskrit
- **Sanskrit belongs to the Indo-European family**, related to Persian, Greek, Latin, German and English
 - Sanskrit *matr* ~ Latin *mater* ~ English *mother*
 - Sanskrit *agni* ~ Latin *ignis* (→ "ignite")
- Other language families in the subcontinent: **Dravidian** (Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam), **Austro-Asiatic** (Munda, Khasi), **Tibeto-Burman**
- ★ Rigvedic Sanskrit shares striking similarity with the **Avestan** language of the Iranian *Avesta* — Sanskrit *soma*/Avestan *haoma*, Sanskrit *sindhu*/Avestan *hindu*. This linguistic link is central to the migration debate

2 Rigvedic Society — Politics Without a State

This is the section that most surprises people, and it is heavily tested.

RIGVEDIC POLITICAL STRUCTURE – what it did NOT have

NO capital city	NO palaces
NO regular taxation	NO standing army
NO written records	NO hereditary bureaucracy
NO territorial kingdom	NO coins

WHAT IT DID HAVE:

RAJA — a war-leader, NOT a territorial monarch
Led cattle raids, was chosen/accepted by the people, shared the spoils. His wealth came from PLUNDER and voluntary gifts (BALI), not tax.

SABHA — assembly of elders / select men

SAMITI — larger general assembly of the people

VIDATHA — oldest assembly; distribution of spoils, ritual

JANA — the PEOPLE / tribe (NOT a territory)

GANA — a group or troop

VIS — clan / settlement unit

GRAMA — village

KULA — family

PUROHITA — the priest who performed the sacrifices

🔑 **The single most important idea here:** in the Rigveda, a *raja* is **not a king of a territory** — he is a **leader of a people**. The word *jana* means *people*, not *land*. (Compare: *janapada* in Chapter 5 literally means "land where the *jana* sets its foot" — **that's the moment tribes become territories**, and it's the whole story of Chapter 5.)

📖 **Rigvedic polity is a peer-to-peer network with a rotating coordinator; Chapter 5's kingdoms are a client-server architecture with a permanent authoritative node.** The transition from *jana* → *janapada* → *mahajanapada* is exactly that migration, and it's driven by iron and agricultural surplus.

🐄 **Cattle = wealth = everything**

The most telling word in the Rigveda:

GAVISHTI = literally "**search for cattle**" — and it is the Rigvedic word for **WAR**. ★

Also: *gavyu* (desiring cattle), *gopa/gopati* (protector of cattle → a term for the chief), *duhitri* (daughter — literally "one who milks").

Implication: wealth was measured in cattle, so warfare was largely **cattle raiding** between clans, not conquest of land. Land was abundant; cattle were the scarce, mobile, productive asset.

The people in Rigvedic society

Term	Meaning	Careful!
Arya	The term Rigvedic people used for themselves — likely meaning "noble/kinsman," a cultural/linguistic self-description	⚠️ NOT a race. The 19th-century "Aryan race" idea is discredited pseudo-science, later weaponised by the Nazis. NCERT is careful here and so should you be
Dasa / Dasyu	Those described as outsiders/opponents — different in language and ritual practice	The word later came to mean slave/servant ★ — a meaning shift that itself records a history of subjugation
Purohita	Priest; composed and recited hymns, performed sacrifices	
Rajan / Raja	War-leader	
Vish / Vaishya	The ordinary people, cattle-keepers and cultivators	

🧠 **Watch the word *dasa* change meaning.** In the Rigveda it names an opposing group. By the later Vedic period it means *slave*. **A word's semantic drift is a historical record of who ended up on top** — this is the kind of observation that makes a Mains answer look sophisticated.

🏹 The Battle of Ten Kings (*Dasarajna*) ★

Element	Detail
Where	On the Parushni river (modern Ravi)
Who	Sudas , king of the Bharata tribe, with his priest Vasishtha
Against	A confederacy of ten tribes/kings , aided by the priest Vishvamitra
Outcome	Sudas and the Bharatas won
Why it matters	The Bharata tribe's name later became " Bharata "/" Bharat " for the whole country ★ (see Ch.1). Also shows the <i>purohita</i> 's political importance — priests picked sides

🌐 The Rivers of the Rigveda

The **Nadistuti Sukta** (Mandala 10) is a hymn listing rivers — a genuine geographical document.

Rigvedic name	Modern name
Sindhu ★ (most mentioned)	Indus
Vitasta	Jhelum
Asikni	Chenab
Parushni ★	Ravi (Battle of Ten Kings)
Vipas	Beas
Shutudri	Sutlej
Saraswati ★	Debated — often identified with the Ghaggar-Hakra
Drishadvati	Chautang (debated)
Kubha	Kabul river
Gomati	Gomal
Suvastu	Swat

★ **Sapta Sindhava** = "land of seven rivers" — the Rigvedic heartland, roughly **Punjab and the north-west**.

🎯 **Prelims-critical:** the Rigvedic geography is the **north-west (Punjab, Haryana, Afghanistan borderlands)**. The **Ganga is mentioned only once** and the **Yamuna thrice** — they are peripheral. The move eastward into the Ganga plain happens in the **Later Vedic** period. Get this direction of movement right; it's a common trap.

3 Early Vedic vs Later Vedic — A Guaranteed Comparison

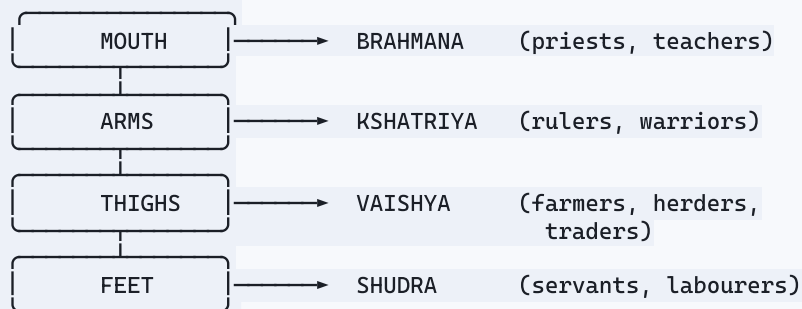
NCERT Class 6 touches this lightly, but **UPSC asks it constantly**. Learn the table.

Dimension	EARLY / RIGVEDIC (~1500–1000 BCE)	LATER VEDIC (~1000–600 BCE)
Texts	Rigveda	Sama, Yajur, Atharva Vedas; Brahmanas, Aranyakas, Upanishads
Geography	Punjab / north-west (<i>Sapta Sindhava</i>)	Ganga-Yamuna doab and eastward (Kuru, Panchala)
Economy	PASTORAL — cattle-rearing dominant; some agriculture	AGRICULTURAL — settled farming dominant
Key metal	Copper/bronze ; <i>ayas</i>	IRON (<i>krishna ayas</i> / <i>shyama ayas</i> = "black metal") ★
Political unit	<i>Jana</i> (people/tribe)	<i>Janapada</i> (territory) → kingdoms
Ruler	<i>Raja</i> = war-leader, no fixed territory	King with territory , elaborate consecration rituals
Assemblies	Sabha and Samiti powerful ; king answerable	Assemblies decline ; king becomes dominant
Taxation	No regular tax ; <i>bali</i> = voluntary offering	Regular tribute/tax emerging
Sacrifices	Simple, performed by the householder	Elaborate, expensive, priest-dominated — <i>Rajasuya, Ashvamedha, Vajapeya</i> ★
Varna	Fluid; <i>Purusha Sukta</i> (a late Mandala 10 hymn) first states four varnas	Hardening into hereditary, birth-based hierarchy
Women	Relatively better position; women composers (Lopamudra, Ghosha, Apala, Vishavara); attended assemblies	Decline — excluded from assemblies and from many rituals
Pottery	Ochre Coloured Pottery (associated)	Painted Grey Ware (PGW) ★

★ **The causal engine of this whole table is IRON.** Iron axes clear the dense, wet Ganga forests; iron ploughshares cut heavy alluvial soil; paddy transplantation multiplies yields. Surplus explodes → permanent settlements → territory matters more than herds → kings with territory, taxes, armies and priests to legitimise them. **Technology → economy → politics**, exactly the chain from Chapter 1.

▲ The Varna System — origins

The **Purusha Sukta** (Rigveda, **Mandala 10** — one of the *latest* parts) describes the sacrifice of a cosmic being, *Purusha*, from whose body the four *varnas* emerged:



Four things UPSC expects you to know about this:

1. It appears in **Mandala 10 — one of the LATEST portions** of the Rigveda. Varna is therefore a **late Vedic development**, not present from the start ★
2. It was initially more **occupational and fluid** than the rigid birth-based caste system of later centuries
3. **Varna (4 categories) ≠ Jati (thousands of birth-based endogamous groups)**. Jati develops much later and is the actual lived structure of caste ★
4. The system **hardened** in the Later Vedic period as priests and warriors consolidated power — and those outside the four varnas were pushed to the margins

🔗 **This is the single most important historical root in the GS1 "Indian Society" syllabus.**

Reservation, social justice, Articles 15/16/17, the Mandal debate — all of it traces back to this hymn's institutionalisation. Cross-reference with your **Polity Class 9 (Ch.4, Mandal/Indra Sawhney)** notes.

👩 Women in the Vedic period

- **Rigvedic women** appear as **composers of hymns**: Lopamudra, Ghosha, Apala, Vishvavara, Romasha
- Women could attend the **sabha** and participate in some rituals; *upanayana* was possible for some
- **Later Vedic**: position declines sharply — excluded from assemblies, from Vedic study, from property; the *Aitareya Brahmana* contains explicitly disparaging statements about daughters
- Later still (Ch.6), the **Upanishads** feature learned women — **Gargi Vachaknavi** (who challenges Yajnavalkya in open debate) and **Maitreyi**

🔗 A useful, evidence-based Mains line: *"The Vedic corpus records both remarkable female intellectual participation and its progressive curtailment — social status was not static but declined with the consolidation of ritual hierarchy."*

4 🏛️ The Aryan Debate — How to Handle It

You will meet this everywhere. **Here's how to think and write about it without stepping in anything.**

What is agreed:

- **Sanskrit is Indo-European**, closely related to Iranian (Avestan), Greek, Latin, Germanic. This is settled linguistics
- The Rigveda's geography is the **north-west**, and its culture is pastoral, horse-centred and sacrifice-based
- Harappan culture is **urban, agricultural, seemingly horseless**, with no evidence of Vedic-style fire sacrifice as its core (though fire altars exist at Kalibangan/Lothal)

What is debated:

Position	Claim
Migration model (mainstream in academic linguistics/genetics)	Indo-Aryan-speaking pastoralists migrated into the subcontinent from Central Asia/Steppe around 2000–1500 BCE, after Harappan decline, and their language and ritual spread
Indigenous/Out-of-India model	Indo-Aryan speech is indigenous ; the Harappans were Vedic; the Saraswati = Ghaggar-Hakra identification places the Rigveda earlier

The **"invasion" version is dead**. Wheeler's massacre-at-Mohenjodaro reading has been discredited (see Ch.3). Modern scholarship, where it supports the model at all, talks about **migration and cultural assimilation over centuries**, not conquest.

Recent evidence: ancient DNA studies (including from **Rakhigarhi**, 2019) found the sampled Harappan individual lacked Steppe ancestry, while later Indian populations show Steppe-related admixture appearing in the 2nd millennium BCE. Interpretations of this differ.

 **How to write about it:** state the evidence, name the models, note the contested points, don't declare a winner. In UPSC, **calibrated neutrality on a live controversy scores better than confident partisanship** — and Prelims will simply ask factual questions (which river, which text, which language family), so make sure the *facts* are solid.

PART B — THE BURIALS: Megaliths and Inamgaon

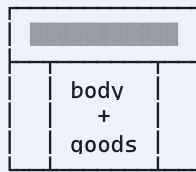
5 What Is a Megalith?

MEGALITH = Greek *mega* (big) + *lithos* (stone) → "**big stone.**"

Large stone structures erected to **mark burials**, found mainly in the **Deccan, South India, the north-east and Kashmir**, roughly **1000 BCE – 100 CE** (broadly the **Iron Age** in peninsular India).

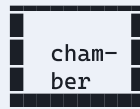
TYPES OF MEGALITHIC BURIAL

1. CIST BURIAL (stone box)



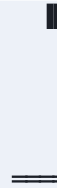
Stone slabs form a box; often with a PORT-HOLE

2. DOLMEN (table-like)



3 or more uprights with a capstone, often above ground

3. MENHIR (standing stone)



a single upright stone marking a grave

(also memorial stones)

4. STONE CIRCLE



Boulders in a circle marking the grave

5. URN BURIAL



Common in Adichanallur (TN)

6. SARCOPHAGUS

(terracotta coffin, often legged, South India)

THE PORT-HOLE – a circular opening cut into one slab of a cist. Why? To allow SUBSEQUENT BURIALS – the grave could be REOPENED to add family members later. Evidence of FAMILY/CLAN burial over time.

Why megaliths are so useful to historians

Feature	What it tells us
Visible above ground	They were meant to be found again — so the grave could be reopened for later family members
Grave goods	Objects buried with the dead: iron tools and weapons , black-and-red ware pottery, beads, horse equipment, gold
Unequal grave goods ★	Some burials are rich, others nearly empty → evidence of social inequality
Iron everywhere	Megalithic culture is firmly an Iron Age phenomenon in peninsular India
Skeletal analysis	Age, sex, diet, disease of ordinary people — the very people texts ignore

Key megalithic sites

Site	Location	Note
Brahmagiri ★	Karnataka	Excavated by Mortimer Wheeler ; one burial had 33 gold beads, carnelian and other beads, a conch shell, copper and iron objects ; another nearby had just a pot and a few stone tools — a stark inequality contrast
Adichanallur ★	Tamil Nadu (Tamraparni river)	Famous urn burials ; iron, bronze and gold objects; large cemetery
Maski, Hallur	Karnataka	Megalithic sites
Junapani	Nagpur, Maharashtra	Stone circles with cup-marks
Mahurjhari, Naikund	Maharashtra	Iron smelting evidence
Burzahom	Kashmir	Menhirs — megalithic tradition in the north
Sanur	Tamil Nadu	Megaliths

🎯 **The Brahmagiri contrast is the classic NCERT teaching point:** two graves, same site, same culture — one lavishly furnished, one nearly bare. **That's your archaeological proof of social stratification**, and it's more reliable than any text, because nobody wrote it down to impress anyone.

⚠️ **But note the limit:** rich grave goods *probably* mean high status — but they could also reflect the wealth of the *survivors*, or a particular ritual obligation. Archaeologists infer status from burials but hedge appropriately. **That hedging is exactly the Chapter 1 methodological habit paying off again.**

6 Inamgaon — A Village We Know Intimately

Inamgaon (Maharashtra, on the Ghod river, a tributary of the Bhima) — a **Chalcolithic** settlement, ~3600–2700 years ago (~1600–700 BCE). Not megalithic, but paired here because burials are its great story.

Evidence	What was found
Burial practice ★	Adults buried in the ground, laid out straight, head pointing NORTH , within the house floor
Grave goods	Pots and occasionally copper; food vessels placed with the body
A remarkable burial ★	A man buried in a large four-legged clay jar (urn) in the courtyard of a five-roomed house — the house was the largest at the site , and the jar burial was unique. Strongly suggests a person of special status, possibly a chief
Crops	Wheat, barley, rice, pulses (lentil, mung, urad), millets, ber, amla , and evidence of sesame, linseed
Animals	Cattle, buffalo, goat, sheep, pig, dog; also hunted — deer, blackbuck, antelope, hare, turtle; and fish
Craft	Copper working, bead making, lime plastering, pottery
Layout	Houses arranged in rows; a possible granary ; an embankment/flood-protection channel

💡 **Why Inamgaon is pedagogically brilliant:** it's a whole village reconstructed *without a single written word*. Diet, houses, crafts, farming, hunting, social hierarchy — all from pots, bones, seeds and graves. **It's the archaeological answer to Chapter 1's complaint that texts only record the powerful.**

7 ★ ★ ★ HARAPPAN vs VEDIC — The Comparison UPSC Loves

Memorise this table. It has been asked directly (2017) and underlies many elimination questions.

Dimension	HARAPPAN	VEDIC (Rigvedic)
Period	~2600–1900 BCE	~1500–1000 BCE
Settlement	URBAN — planned cities	RURAL/PASTORAL — no cities
Economy	Agriculture + long-distance trade + craft	Cattle-rearing dominant; limited trade
Metal	Copper, bronze, gold, silver. NO IRON	Copper/bronze early; IRON in Later Vedic
Writing	Yes — but undeciphered	NO writing — purely oral
Horse	Absent/disputed ; never on seals	CENTRAL — chariots, horse sacrifice ★
Main evidence	Archaeology	Texts
Religion	Mother goddess, pipal tree, animals, possible proto-Shiva; no clear fire-sacrifice centrality	Fire sacrifice (yajna) central; Indra, Agni, Soma, Varuna
Burial	Simple, modest grave goods	Cremation predominant (later); megaliths are a <i>separate</i> peninsular tradition
Political	Unknown; no royal names or palaces	<i>Raja</i> as war-leader; sabha, samiti
Geography	Indus + Ghaggar-Hakra, Gujarat, Punjab, Sindh, Haryana, Rajasthan	<i>Sapta Sindhava</i> — Punjab/north-west
Cities/Drainage	Elaborate	None
Weights/standards	Highly standardised	Not evidenced
Cotton	Yes — world's earliest	Wool more prominent
Society	Differentiation visible, but no varna evidence	Varna system emerges (late Rigveda)

🎯 **The compressed version to hold in your head: Harappa = cities, drains, trade, writing, NO horse, NO iron. Vedic = cattle, chariots, fire sacrifice, oral texts, HORSE central, iron later.**

Almost every Prelims question on this comparison is answerable from those two lines.

Prelims

Topic	Exactly what to know
Four Vedas ★★ ★	Rigveda = oldest, 1,028 hymns, 10 mandalas ; Sama = music ; Yajur = ritual formulae; Atharva = magic/medicine
Rigvedic gods	Indra most hymns; Agni second; Mandala 9 = Soma
Purusha Sukta ★	Mandala 10 (late); origin of four varnas
Nasadiya Sukta	Mandala 10; the creation/scepticism hymn
Battle of Ten Kings ★	Parushni (Ravi) ; Sudas of the Bharatas won; Vasishtha vs Vishvamitra
Rivers	Sindhu=Indus, Parushni=Ravi, Vitasta=Jhelum, Asikni=Chenab, Vipas=Beas, Shutudri=Sutlej
Sapta Sindhava	Land of seven rivers — Rigvedic heartland, north-west
Gavishti ★	"Search for cattle" = war
Dasa/Dasyu	Opponents; later came to mean slave
Sabha/Samiti/Vidatha	Assemblies; powerful in early, decline later
Iron in Later Vedic ★	<i>Krishna ayas / shyama ayas</i> = black metal
PGW	Painted Grey Ware = Later Vedic marker
Megalith types	Cist, dolmen, menhir, stone circle, urn burial, port-hole
Brahmagiri ★	Karnataka; excavated by Wheeler ; unequal grave goods
Adichanallur ★	Tamil Nadu; urn burials
Inamgaon ★	Maharashtra; burials with head to NORTH ; man in a jar in a five-roomed house's courtyard
Harappan vs Vedic ★★ ★	The full comparison table above
Women composers	Lopamudra, Ghosha, Apala, Vishvavara

Traps to watch:

- **"The Ganga is prominent in the Rigveda"** → **FALSE**. Mentioned **once**. Rigvedic geography is the **north-west**
- **"Varna appears throughout the Rigveda"** → **FALSE**. Only in **Mandala 10**, one of the latest portions
- **"Rigvedic kings collected regular taxes"** → **FALSE**. *Bali* was **voluntary**; regular taxation is Later Vedic onward
- **"Megaliths are found only in South India"** → **FALSE**. Also the Deccan, north-east, and Kashmir (menhirs at Burzahom)
- **"Sabha and samiti grew stronger over time"** → **FALSE**. They **declined** as kingship strengthened

Mains

- **Art & Culture:** Vedic literature as heritage; Samaveda as the origin of Indian classical music; the oral transmission tradition (**UNESCO Intangible Cultural Heritage, 2008**)
- **Indian Society (GS1):** *"Trace the origins of the varna system and assess its transformation into the jati-based caste order."* Cite the **Purusha Sukta**, its **late** position in the Rigveda, and the varna/jati distinction
- **Gender:** the documented rise-and-decline of women's position from Rigvedic to Later Vedic
- **Methodology:** *"Compare the value of textual and archaeological sources using the Vedic period and the megalithic cultures as examples."* This chapter is *purpose-built* for that question

Glossary

Term	Meaning
Veda	"Knowledge"; the four earliest Sanskrit texts
Sukta	"Well-said" — a hymn
Mandala	A "book"/division of the Rigveda (10 in total)
Purohita	Priest who performed sacrifices for the raja
Jana	The people/tribe (not territory)
Gana	Group, troop
Vis	Clan/settlement unit
Sabha / Samiti / Vidatha	Vedic assemblies
Bali	Voluntary offering/tribute to the raja
Gavishti	"Search for cattle" = war
Arya	Self-description of the Vedic people (cultural/linguistic, not racial)
Dasa / Dasyu	Opponents/outsideers; later = slave/servant
Varna	The four-fold order: Brahmana, Kshatriya, Vaishya, Shudra
Jati	Birth-based endogamous groups; a later , distinct development
Yajna	Sacrifice/ritual offering into fire
Ashvamedha	Horse sacrifice asserting royal supremacy
Megalith	"Big stone" burial monument
Cist	Stone box burial
Dolmen	Chamber of uprights with a capstone
Menhir	Single standing stone
Port-hole	Circular opening in a cist slab allowing later burials
Sarcophagus	Terracotta coffin, often legged (South India)
Black-and-red ware	Characteristic megalithic pottery
PGW	Painted Grey Ware — Later Vedic pottery marker
Chalcolithic	Copper-Stone Age (Inamgaon)
Krishna ayas	"Black metal" = iron

90-Second Recap

1. **Perfect inversion of Chapter 3:** Harappans = objects without readable text; Vedic = text without objects.
2. **Four Vedas.** Rigveda oldest — **1,028 hymns, 10 mandalas**. Sama = music, Yajur = ritual, Atharva = magic/medicine.
3. **Transmitted ORALLY for ~3,000 years** using redundant recitation patterns that function as checksums.
4. **Gods:** Indra (most), Agni, Soma (Mandala 9), Varuna, Ushas — forces of nature, war god foremost.
5. **Rigvedic politics:** *raja* = **war-leader, not territorial king**; no capital, no tax, no standing army; **sabha and samiti** matter; *jana* = people, not land.

6. **Cattle = wealth.** *Gavishti* ("search for cattle") = **war**.
 7. **Battle of Ten Kings** on the **Parushni (Ravi)**; **Sudas** of the **Bharatas** won — the name behind "Bharat."
 8. **Rigvedic geography = north-west** (*Sapta Sindhava*). Ganga barely mentioned.
 9. **Later Vedic:** iron arrives → move **east** into the Ganga plain → agriculture → territory → kings, taxes, elaborate sacrifices, declining assemblies, hardening varna, worsening position of women.
 10. **Varna originates in the Purusha Sukta, Mandala 10** — one of the **latest** Rigvedic portions. **Varna ≠ jati**.
 11. **Megaliths** = big-stone burials, Iron Age peninsular India: cist, dolmen, menhir, stone circle, urn burial; **port-holes** allowed reopening for family burials.
 12. **Brahmagiri** (Wheeler) shows **unequal grave goods** = archaeological proof of social inequality. **Adichanallur** = urn burials.
 13. **Inamgaon** = Chalcolithic Maharashtra village; burials head to **north**; the **jar burial in a five-roomed house** suggests a chief.
 14. **The Harappan vs Vedic table** is the highest-value takeaway. Harappa: cities, drains, trade, writing, no horse, no iron. Vedic: cattle, chariots, fire sacrifice, oral texts, horse central.
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Test Yourself

Prelims style

1. With reference to the difference between the culture of Rigvedic Aryans and Indus Valley people, which is/are correct?
 1. Rigvedic Aryans used the horse; Indus Valley people have not left convincing evidence of it.
 2. Rigvedic Aryans knew iron; Indus Valley people did not.
 3. Indus Valley people had cities; Rigvedic Aryans did not. → *1 and 3 only. **Iron is Later Vedic**, not Rigvedic — a subtle and frequently exploited distinction.*
2. The Purusha Sukta, which describes the origin of the four varnas, occurs in — → *Mandala 10 of the Rigveda — one of its latest portions.*
3. Consider the following statements about megaliths:
 1. Port-holes in cist burials allowed the grave to be reopened for later burials.
 2. Megaliths are found only in peninsular India.
 3. Megalithic burials are associated with the Iron Age. → *1 and 3 only. Menhirs occur at Burzahom in Kashmir and megaliths exist in the north-east.*
4. The Battle of Ten Kings was fought on the banks of the — → *Parushni (modern Ravi).*
5. "Gavishti," a Rigvedic term, literally means — → *"Search for cattle" — and was used to mean war.*

Mains style

6. *"The transition from the Rigvedic to the Later Vedic period was driven primarily by the adoption of iron technology."* Critically examine. **(250 words)**
7. Trace the origins of the varna system and assess how it differed from the later jati-based caste order. **(250 words)**
8. *"Burials tell us what texts conceal."* Discuss with reference to megalithic cultures and Inamgaon. **(150 words)**

Self-check (out loud, no notes):

- Name the four Vedas and one distinguishing feature of each.
 - Why was the Rigvedic raja **not** a king in the modern sense?
 - Give four differences between Harappan and Rigvedic culture.
 - What is a port-hole, and why does it matter?
 - What does the Brahmagiri evidence prove, and what are its limits?
 - Which Mandala contains the Purusha Sukta, and why does that placement matter?
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